

THE HISTORY OF GDANSK

A City of Trade, War, and Freedom

1. EARLY BEGINNINGS (997 AD)

Gdansk, one of Poland's oldest cities, was first mentioned in historical records in 997 AD when Saint Adalbert of Prague visited the settlement to baptize the local inhabitants. Situated at the mouth of the Vistula River on the shores of the Baltic Sea, it quickly grew into a vital trade, craftsmanship, and fishing hub for the early Polish state under the Piast dynasty.

2. TEUTONIC KNIGHTS & HANSEATIC LEAGUE

In 1308, the city was violently taken over by the Teutonic Knights, marking the beginning of over a century of rule by the Order. During this time, the city—known as Danzig in German—joined the Hanseatic League, a powerful commercial and defensive confederation of merchant guilds and market towns. This membership brought immense wealth, established crucial maritime trade routes, and transformed the city into a major European port.

3. THE GOLDEN AGE (15TH - 17TH CENTURY)

Following a successful rebellion against the Teutonic Knights in 1454, Gdansk was reincorporated into the Kingdom of Poland. The city enjoyed unparalleled autonomy and political privileges. The 16th and 17th centuries are considered its "Golden Age." As the primary gateway for massive Polish grain exports to the rest of Europe, Gdansk became the wealthiest, most populous, and most cosmopolitan city in the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth, attracting merchants, architects, and scientists from across the continent.

4. PRUSSIAN RULE AND THE FREE CITY

During the Partitions of Poland in the late 18th century, Gdansk was annexed by the Kingdom of Prussia. It remained under German control (with a brief interruption as a free city during the Napoleonic Wars) until the end of World War I. In 1920, under the terms of the Treaty of Versailles, it was established as the "Free City of Danzig," a semi-autonomous city-state under the protection of the League of Nations. During the interwar period, ethnic and political tensions between its German majority and Polish minority grew intensely.

5. WORLD WAR II (1939 - 1945)

World War II officially began in Gdansk on September 1, 1939, when the German battleship Schleswig-Holstein fired upon the Polish military transit depot at Westerplatte. The heroic defense of the Polish Post Office by civilian postal workers is another legendary chapter of this tragic period. By the end of the war in 1945, advancing Soviet forces and heavy artillery fire had reduced the historic city center to smoldering rubble.

6. SOLIDARITY AND THE MODERN ERA

After the war, the borders of Europe shifted, and Gdansk was fully returned to Poland. In a massive national effort, the completely destroyed Main Town was meticulously reconstructed to reflect its historic Renaissance and Gothic charm. In August 1980, the Gdansk Shipyard became the birthplace of the Solidarity (Solidarnosc) movement led by electrician Lech Walesa. This first independent trade union in the Soviet bloc played a crucial role in the eventual peaceful collapse of communism in Central and Eastern Europe. Today, Gdansk stands as a thriving modern metropolis and a powerful symbol of freedom.